

Title Page

Divine Purpose in Human Suffering: Theodicy and Moral Formation in Job and Mencius

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Abstract

This essay reads the book of Job alongside *Mengzi* 6B15 (the fifteenth section of "Gaozi II") through cross-textual hermeneutics, arguing that the two texts generate not a synthesis but a productive tension over the role of suffering in moral formation. Although a mature literature now treats the problem of evil within classical Chinese philosophy, and comparative theology has refined its cross-textual methods, no sustained reading has yet set Job beside the *Mengzi* on the question of how suffering forms character. This essay attempts that reading in three moves: it adopts Archie Lee's cross-textual method, which lets each text argue in its own idiom; it takes *Mengzi* 6B15, a passage far more explicit than the *Analects* about the pedagogy of adversity, as the Confucian anchor; and it makes Job 23:10 ("when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold," כִּי בִּחְנוּנֵי כֶּזֶבֶב אֵצִא) the hinge of the argument. Read with Mencian eyes, Job's metallurgical image betrays a teleological instinct that Greco-Roman frameworks—Stoic endurance, Platonic ascent, Leibnizian optimism—have tended to obscure. The structural parallel between *tummâ* (תְּמִמָּה, integrity) and *duan* (端, the moral "sprouts"), both qualities that suffering refines rather than creates, is the essay's central contribution. Job restrains the Mencian drift toward over-systematization; *Mengzi* keeps the Joban narrative from collapsing into nihilism.

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